

Tap
in

THIS IS BLACK GEN Z

KEY FINDINGS REPORT

JULY 2022



ABOUT THIS REPORT



#ThisIsBlackGenZ is a research report capturing the voices of Black Gen Z Talent in the UK through a mixed methods approach. Over 2,000 Black people between the ages of 16–25 were surveyed and interviewed for the report in a bid to tap into their experiences of being Black in the workplace, and to understand what motivates them to stay and ultimately perform. The research focuses on how Black Gen Z find jobs, how they navigate the application process, what types of support they want to see from current and future employers, and how authentic they feel they can be in the workplace. This will be the first time a piece of research of this kind has been conducted amongst this important and underrepresented population. The benefit of work like this is clear. We must first seek to understand those among us in order to create and foster workplace cultures of inclusion where talent from all backgrounds can thrive.

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ABOUT THE COMPANY

TapIn is a social-first agency specialising in Gen Z Recruitment Marketing – we focus on supporting employers in hiring diverse talent. We aim to understand the Gen Z talent experience, and this project aims to ‘TapIn to Black Britain’. The company is home to a talented team of diverse creative strategists, content creators, Gen Z experts and influencers in the industry.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

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FOREWORD



To create truly inclusive workplaces, employers need to both understand and empathise with their employees. To do this, employers need to listen to the voices of current and potential employees who come from marginalised groups, and act on their priorities for change. This research report provides insights and experiences from one such group in the UK – Black young people aged 16 to 25, or Black Gen Z.

Why are we focusing on Black Gen Z? I grew up in a deprived neighbourhood in Zambia, and once I came to the UK, I witnessed first-hand how challenging it is for Black Gen Z to get the jobs and careers they want to. While I was one of the lucky few – I was exposed to a range of companies as an intern before entering the world of work – I am acutely aware of the challenges facing Black Gen Z when it comes to employment.

UK Government data hint at the challenges faced by Black people in the UK labour market, indicating lower participation to higher education and underrepresentation across employment sectors. However, to our knowledge there have been no recent, large-scale studies taking an in-depth look at Black people's experiences of work in the UK, and certainly none focusing specifically on Black Gen Z in comparison to their non-Black Gen Z peers.

#ThisIsBlackGenZ therefore fills a vital gap for employers, and highlights specific barriers faced by Black Gen Z – such as limited feedback on job applications, microaggressions in the workplace, an inability to be their authentic selves – which holds them back compared to their White Gen Z counterparts.



Milimo Banji,
CEO and Founder,
TapIn

Importantly, we not only explore challenges but also the positive experiences and proposed solutions from Black Gen Z to ensure they can thrive in truly diverse, equitable and inclusive workplaces. These include practical recommendations to create more transparent, creative and supportive recruitment processes; offer fair opportunities for Black Gen Z to develop and progress; and create workplaces where Black Gen Z are safe, supported and valued.

Our research tells us that Black Gen-Z are looking to join organisations that are taking a stand against the status quo and that are starting the journey to get their own house in order. At TapIn, we also know that more and more employers are motivated to act on diversity, equity, inclusion and belonging (DEIB). However, employers are not always sure where to start or how to make their DEIB work as effective as possible.

The first step on the journey to true workplace inclusion is understanding that it's not always going to be easy and that you certainly won't always get it right. But by including Black colleagues and partners in the conversation, you'll be well on the way to doing the right thing. We therefore hope that these findings and recommendations – based on the voices and experiences of over 2,000 Black young people in the UK – help to inspire meaningful action in your workplace.

Maya Angelou once said – “now that I know better, I do better”. Today, when talking about inequality and systemic racism, it's no longer acceptable to say we don't know better. Therefore, we must do better.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

What are the research aims?

#ThisIsBlackGenZ aims to capture the voices of Black Gen Z in the UK – to understand their experiences and priorities for change. At TapIn, we know that employers must first seek to understand Black Gen Z to create and foster inclusive workplace cultures where talent from all backgrounds can thrive.



Why is this research needed?

There is a common misconception that employers do not need to think about Gen Z, as they are not yet in the workplace. However, Gen Z are now 16–25 years old – they are either already working or actively looking for jobs. An estimated 12.6 million young people belong to Gen Z in the UK – at 19% of the population, employers cannot afford to ignore Gen Z any longer.

In 2020, Black Gen Z came to prominence when hundreds of thousands of Black young people stood up to be counted in the Black Lives Matter (BLM) Movement in the UK, following the deaths of Breonna Taylor, George Floyd, Tony McDade and Ahmaud Arbery in the USA. While these atrocities took place thousands of miles away and in the midst of a global pandemic, Black Gen Z took a stand to call for racial injustice in the UK to be understood and addressed once and for all. The BLM movement rapidly led to stakeholders across the private and public sectors to look inwards and have difficult conversations around race in the UK.

Two years on, we see a mixed picture in terms of concrete change. When it comes to the world of work, employers' interest in diversity, equity and inclusion has undoubtedly increased. However, Black people continue to be underrepresented across almost all employment sectors in the UK. Stated commitments to diversity are not yet consistently leading to diverse, equitable or inclusive workplaces.

To address the underrepresentation of Black Gen Z in the workplace and to ensure employers reap the benefits of a truly diverse workforce, it is essential to understand what motivates Black Gen Z to apply to jobs, what drives them to perform, and what makes them stay with an employer.

TapIn is on a mission to prepare 100 million young, diverse people for the world of work. We are pleased to present this pioneering, industry-first research into Black Gen Z perceptions and experiences of the workplace. This is the first time a piece of research of this kind has been conducted amongst this important and underrepresented population.



KEY

FINDINGS

Key Finding 1:

Black Gen Z want to work for employers who take authentic action on diversity, equity and inclusion

For Black Gen Z, authentic action on diversity, equity and inclusion (DEI) means:

- Reflecting **diversity in the workforce** in terms of race, gender identity, sexual orientation, disability, neurodiversity and religion
- Promoting **respect and understanding** for diverse cultures in the workplace
- Ensuring **transparency, support and accountability** when dealing with discrimination or misconduct in the workplace

Black Gen Z value employers' DEI initiatives at the recruitment stage – **69 per cent of Black Gen Z appreciate seeing people who look like them in job ads**, compared to less than 20 per cent of White Gen Z. **Over 60 per cent of Black Gen Z prefer to apply to job roles targeted at Black candidates**, while only 11 per cent of White Gen Z want to see job roles targeted at White candidates.

Black Gen Z are **alert to 'inauthentic' DEI efforts from employers**, and do their research to determine employers' DEI credentials. Before applying for jobs, Black Gen Z **check company websites, read reviews** on sites like Glassdoor, and **connect with current employees** to understand whether a workplace is truly diverse, equitable and inclusive. **Companies' presence on social media** is another key factor at the application stage – Black Gen Z feel more able to trust employers who make active efforts to connect with them, and companies' social media channels are an important way to determine their culture, ethos and vision.

Once in the workplace, Black Gen Z are wary of employers **who make statements about DEI, but fail to follow through with meaningful action**. For example, a **lack of diversity at senior levels** is a concern, as it suggests Black Gen Z talent may not be able to progress at an organisation. Employers who do not have **transparent processes to deal with racism and other forms of discrimination** are also a red flag. While Black Gen Z would of course prefer not to experience discrimination at work, they are much more likely to leave (and to experience harm) when employers fail to act on racism.

Key Finding 2: Black Gen Z navigate numerous barriers to employment compared to their non-Black peers

During the job application process, **Black Gen Z are less likely than their White Gen Z peers to receive feedback on their performance.** This means that, if they are unsuccessful in a recruitment process, they are often unsure and are unclear about how to improve in future. Black Gen Z are also put off by job ads which don't include salary information. They feel employers who do not share this information are less trustworthy; additionally, without this information, they are unable to determine whether the position meets their financial requirements.

Black Gen Z navigate barriers related to racial discrimination during the application process. Due to experiences or concerns of discrimination, **22 per cent of Black Gen Z have changed their names on job applications** to improve their chances of success, compared to only 7 per cent of White Gen Z. Meanwhile, **52 per cent of Black Gen Z women and 37 per cent of non-binary Black Gen Z do not feel comfortable wearing their natural hair to job interviews.** By contrast, 76 per cent of their White Gen Z peers do feel comfortable doing this. When deciding whether or not to wear their natural hair to interviews, Black Gen Z highlight concerns about being perceived as unprofessional or experiencing microaggressions. They express frustration at the emotional labour required to navigate these concerns, which detracts from the energy available to excel in the interview process.

Once in the workplace, **only 31 per cent of Black Gen Z feel able to be their authentic selves,** compared to 66 per cent of White Gen Z. This means the vast majority of Black Gen Z feel the need to code-switch and change their self-presentation to 'fit in' with their colleagues. When they are unable to be their authentic selves at work, Black Gen Z can feel **stressed, anxious and demotivated,** which has a negative impact on their mental health and productivity.

Key Finding 3: Black Gen Z want to thrive – not just survive – in the workplace

Only **36 per cent of Black Gen Z feel supported to pursue their professional interests** in the workplace, compared to 48 per cent of Asian Gen Z and 58 per cent of White Gen Z. This results in low confidence in expectations around progression – only **29 per cent of Black Gen Z report feeling satisfied with their chances of securing a promotion,** compared to 52 per cent of White Gen Z and 62 per cent of Asian Gen Z.

In workplaces where they can be their authentic selves, there are huge benefits for Black Gen Z and their employers. When they thrive – rather than just survive – in the workplace, Black Gen Z **perform to the best of their ability,** feel **passionate and committed** about their work, and are **more likely to stay with their employer.**

Overall, we find that Black Gen Z are more likely to thrive with employers who:

- Prioritise **employee wellbeing,** including the specific needs of employees who are Black and/or from other marginalised groups.
- Create a **positive work environment,** in which co-workers and managers treat each other fairly, respectfully and work together collaboratively.
- Provide **fair opportunities for progression,** including professional development and training
- Facilitate **work-based mentors** who are Black or from other racially minoritised groups, to provide support on professional and personal issues.
- Recognise, value and reward the **strengths and contributions** of employees who are Black and/or from other marginalised groups.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Based on our key findings, what should employers do to reach, recruit and retain Black Gen Z talent?



DIVERSITY

Ensure your recruitment process is transparent, creative and supportive

Develop transparent, creative job ads. Clearly state the salary, and explain what the application process involves at each stage. This helps Black Gen Z to trust employers, to evaluate whether the position meets their financial requirements, and to determine whether they have the required time and capacity for the application process. Use your social media platforms to advertise jobs, including opportunities that are specifically targeted at Black Gen Z candidates.

Minimise bias when assessing candidates. Name-blind job applications to minimise potential bias in the recruitment process – and tell your candidates that you do this, as potential discrimination related to non-White names can be a source of anxiety for Black Gen Z. Provide training for all those involved in recruitment, to minimise bias and microaggressions in the hiring process.

Provide feedback to all candidates. Black Gen Z currently receive insufficient feedback on their job applications – this means that they don't always know how to improve in future. Providing opportunities for feedback at each stage of the application process is therefore a vital form of support for your candidates.

EQUITY

Offer fair opportunities for Black Gen Z to develop and progress

Offer well-paid jobs with clear routes to progression. Black Gen Z value jobs that offer financial security and opportunities for personal development across a wide range of sectors, including those in which Black people have been historically underrepresented. Ensure your roles are fairly remunerated (with the Real Living Wage as a baseline), with transparent criteria and processes for promotion.

Provide targeted professional development and training opportunities. Ensure that Black Gen Z talent has space to grow and develop at your company, including through targeted professional development and training opportunities. Actively involve Black Gen Z employees in activities that will lead to progression in their careers. At present, Black Gen Z do not feel they are sufficiently supported to progress at work, nor do they see themselves reflected in senior positions.



INCLUSION

Create a workplace where Black Gen Z are safe, supported and valued

Create an inclusive culture. Encourage all your employees to respect diverse cultures. This includes improving awareness of the experiences and potential challenges faced by marginalised groups, and celebrating employees from a range of backgrounds. Black Gen Z are more likely to feel comfortable being their authentic selves – and therefore realise their full potential – in such workplaces.

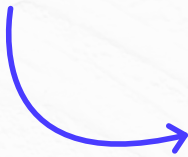
Acknowledge, value and reward Black employees' contributions fairly. In workplaces where Black Gen Z describe being able to thrive, their work and strengths are acknowledged, valued and rewarded fairly. Embed these practices at all levels in your organisation to ensure Black Gen Z employees are valued as much as their peers.

Provide mentoring and pastoral support. Set up mentoring and buddying schemes for Black Gen Z employees. This provides targeted pastoral support so that Black Gen Z are supported professionally and personally by someone who is more likely to share their lived experiences.

Deal with discrimination transparently and effectively. Ensure there are transparent, consistent processes to report and address discrimination – whether experienced with colleagues or customers. Where it occurs, provide support for employees who have experienced discrimination, and ensure that the issues are understood and dealt with in a timely way.

INTRODUCTION

WHY FOCUS ON BLACK GEN Z?



There are 1.8 million Black people in England and Wales, representing 3.3% of the population.¹ However, Black people are under-represented in almost all employment sectors in the UK.² Black people also face significant barriers in accessing higher education – 52 per cent of Black 18-year-olds attending state schools did not achieve higher education places in 2020.³

In this study, we define **Black Gen Z** as people who identify as:

- Aged 16 to 25
- Based in the UK
- African, Caribbean, White and Black Caribbean, White and Black African or another Mixed Background

The Black Talent Research project focuses on UK-based 16 to 25-year-olds who identify as Black, or 'Black Gen Z', who are about to enter or already in the workplace. To ensure Black people have fair education, employment and training (EET) opportunities and outcomes – and to ensure that employers benefit from a diverse and inclusive workforce – it is essential to understand how best to reach, recruit and retain Black Gen-Z talent.

In the first research of its kind, in March to May 2022 we surveyed over 2,000 Black Gen Z students and employees to understand:

- What motivates Black Gen Z talent to apply for jobs?
- What drives Black Gen Z talent to perform at work?
- What makes Black Gen Z talent stay with employers?

We also conducted qualitative interviews with 50 Black Gen Z students and employees, to gain an in-depth understanding of their views and experiences.

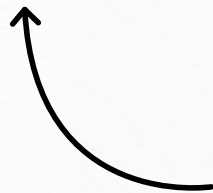
¹People who identified as 'Black African', 'Black Caribbean' or 'Black Other' in 2011 Census – Office of National Statistics (2020), '[Population of England and Wales](#)'.

²The proportion of Black people employed across sectors ranges from 1.5 per cent in the Energy and Manufacturing sectors to 2.8 per cent in Banking and Finance. The Transport and Communication sector and Public Administration, Education and Health sectors are the only sectors in which Black people are represented or over-represented compared to the wider population (3.2 per cent and 4.3 per cent respectively). Calculated using ONS (2021) '[Employment by Sector](#)' data.

³UCAS (2022) '[Entry rates into higher education](#)'.

Why does this matter to employers?

The business case for improved diversity, equity and inclusion is well-established. Diverse, inclusive companies are more likely to financially outperform their less-diverse peers,^{4 5} and benefit from diversity of talent and thought, which is associated with greater creativity, innovation and problem solving.⁶ When employers prioritise inclusion – making all employees feel like they are valued members of the organisation – employees are at their most productive, committed and collaborative.⁷ Reaching, recruiting and retaining Black Gen Z is therefore not just the right thing to do, but a significant opportunity for employers to benefit from more diverse talent.



⁴ McKinsey & Co (2020) Diversity wins – how inclusion matters.

⁵ Herring (2009) Does diversity pay? Race, Gender and the Business Case for Diversity. American Sociological Review (74), pp. 208-224.

⁶ Reynolds & Lewis (2017) Teams solve problems faster when they're more diverse. Harvard Business Review.

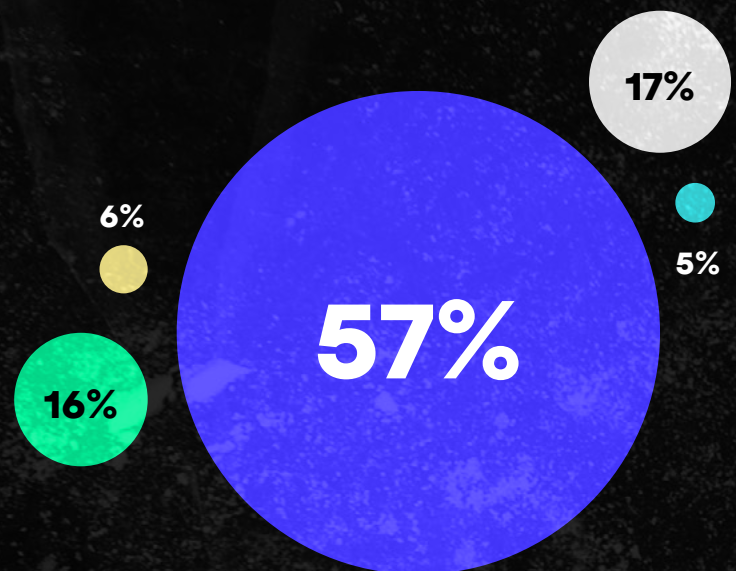
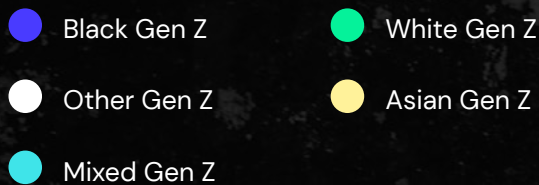
⁷ Bersin & Deloitte (2019) Why Diversity and Inclusion has become a business priority.

WHO TOOK PART?

SURVEY SAMPLE

In total, 5,828 people from 133 countries completed our survey. In this report, we focus on key findings from 3,510 Gen Z respondents based in the UK, and in particular, the **2,001 respondents who identify as Black Gen Z in the UK** (57 per cent of our UK Gen Z sample).

You can read more about the characteristics of our full survey sample in Appendix A.



Looking at our Black Gen Z survey sample in the UK:

62%
16 to 19 years

38%
20 to 25 years

Age: 62 per cent are aged 16 to 19 years, with 38 per cent aged 20 to 25 years.

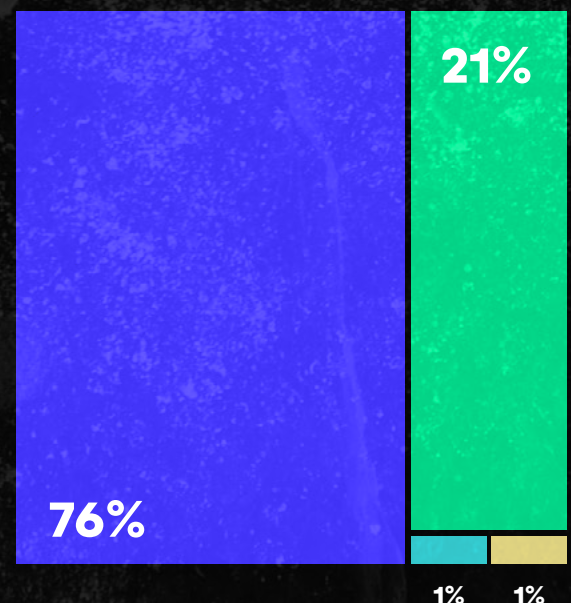
Gender



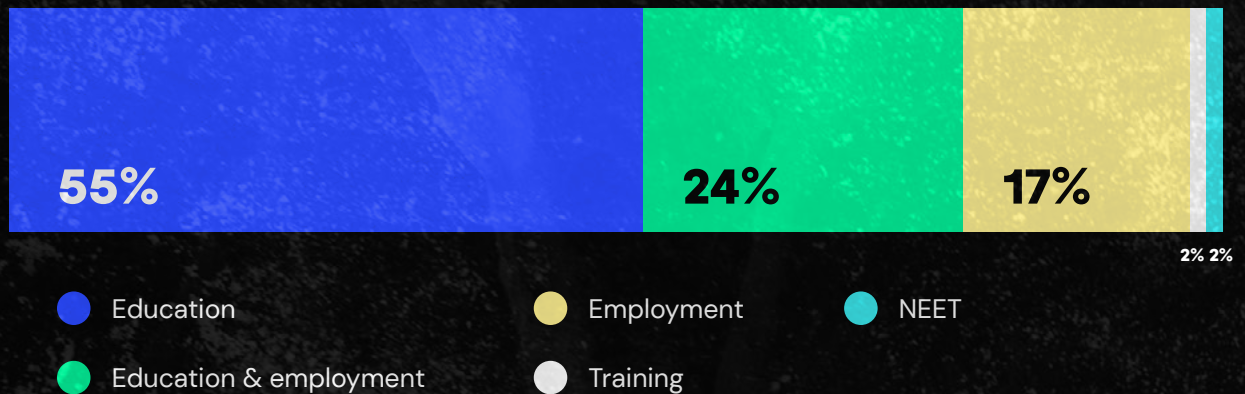
Gender: over three-quarters identify as female, with 21 per cent identifying as male and one per cent as non-binary.

*Includes participants who identified as cisgender or transgender female

**Includes participants who identified as cisgender or transgender male



Employment, education and training

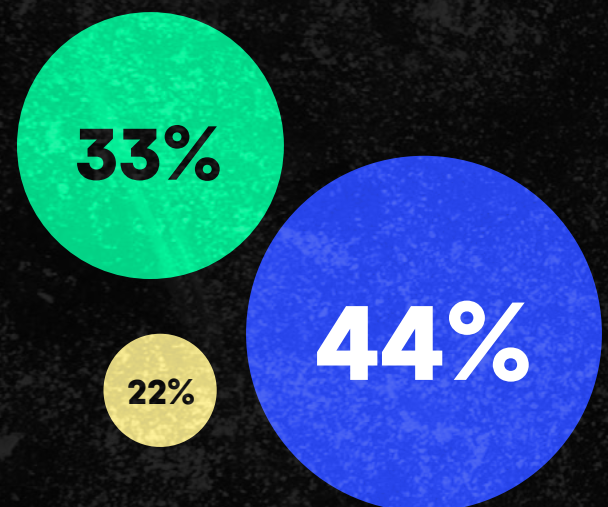


Employment, education and training: just over half are in education (55 per cent), with a quarter in both education and employment (24 per cent). 17 per cent are in employment, with smaller numbers in training (2 per cent) and not in education, employment or training (NEET – 2 per cent).

Job seekers

Job seekers: the majority of respondents are looking for a job (66 per cent): 44 per cent in the next 1 to 3 months; and 22 per cent in the next 3 to 12 months. The remaining 33 per cent are not currently looking for work.

- Looking for a job in the next 1–3 months
- Looking for a job in the next 3–12 months
- Not currently looking for a job



Interview sample

We interviewed 50 Black Gen Z students and employees. 74 per cent of our interviewees identify as female, 20 per cent as male and 6 per cent as non-binary. The majority (58 per cent) are looking for a job in the next 1–3 months, with 20 per cent looking for a job in the next 3–12 months and 22 per cent not currently looking for a job.

01 – WHAT MATTERS TO BLACK GEN Z



1.1

WHAT MOTIVATES BLACK GEN Z WHEN IT COMES TO WORK?

Black Gen Z want to work for organisations with **diverse, equitable and inclusive workplaces**, who **pay attention to employee wellbeing**, and those who offer equal opportunities to employees who are Black and from other marginalised groups.



Black male employee
20–25 years old

“Incorporating culture and diversity into a workplace, that’s very important. I feel like having a diverse group of employees and colleagues of different cultures, beliefs and religion definitely makes [people] feel more comfortable to work in an environment where they feel like they can relate to others.”



Black male student and part-time employee
20–25 years old

“When in a workplace, I’m not based on the colour of my skin, but I’m based on my ability. So if I’ve come to work for you, obviously, I’m not saying don’t see colour, but I’m saying, look at my abilities and then judge; what I actually offer to the team.”

Thinking about their own needs, Black Gen Z value **opportunities for professional and personal development**. When asked what they value most from employment, over half of Black Gen Z say ‘personal development and becoming a better version of themselves’ (55 per cent).

Financial incentives are also important for Black Gen Z: employment is primarily valued as a means to make money by our survey sample (to satisfy their lifestyle – 61 per cent; to cover every day expenses – 49 per cent).

55%

Personal development and becoming a better version of themselves

61%

To satisfy their lifestyle

49%

To cover everyday expenses

Figure 1: What do you value most from employment?

1.2

WHAT DOES DIVERSITY AND INCLUSION MEAN TO BLACK GEN Z?

At the recruitment stage...

Ensuring jobs ads are **visible and accessible to Black candidates** and including **representation of Black employees** are important to Black Gen Z:

- 61 per cent of Black Gen Z **prefer to apply to job roles targeted to candidates from the same ethnic group as them**. This is much higher than White Gen Z, where only 10 per cent agree with this statement (Figure B2 – please see Appendix B).
- 69 per cent of Black Gen Z **value seeing people who look like them in images used to advertise jobs**. Again, this is much higher than other groups – only 19 per cent of White Gen Z state that this is important to them (Figure B3).



Figure 2: I would prefer to apply to job roles with target candidates that are the same ethnic group as me

61%

of Black Gen Z strongly agree or agree

10%

of White Gen Z strongly agree or agree

Figure 3: Seeing people who look like me reflected in the images used to advertise a job is an important factor when deciding to apply for a job

69%

of Black Gen Z strongly agree or agree

19%

of White Gen Z strongly agree or agree

However, Black Gen Z also do their own research to learn how diverse a company is. To do this, Black Gen Z typically go to **company websites or careers pages** (32 per cent), **social media** (31 per cent) or they **connect with current employees who look like them** (17 per cent). Connecting with current employees is an important way for Black Gen Z to assess the authenticity of companies' diversity and inclusion statements, and to understand whether they go beyond words and take meaningful action to support their employees.

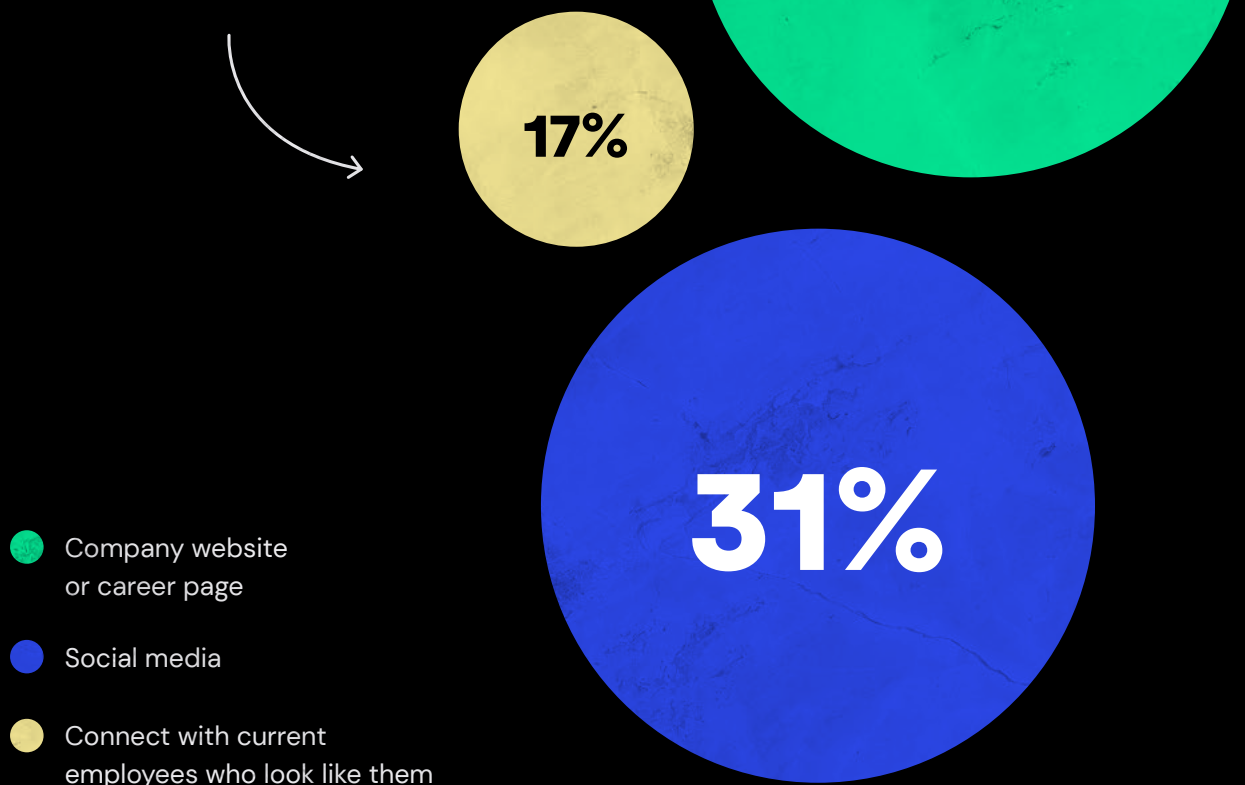


Figure 4: Where do you go first when you want to learn about how diverse a company is?



Black male student and part-time employee
20–25 years old

“If you see the board members and then there’s no diversity throughout it, it makes you seem like, am I ever gonna get a chance to progress throughout the company?”

In the workplace...

Black Gen Z see the following as essential diversity and inclusion actions for companies:

- **Recruiting people from diverse backgrounds** in terms of race, gender identity, sexual orientation, disability and other characteristics
- **Creating an inclusive workplace** by allowing people to be their authentic selves at work, including how they wear their hair, the food they bring to work, celebrating a range of religious holidays, and organising social activities beyond after-work drinks (which excludes those who do not drink alcohol and/or those who are unable to attend social events outside working hours).
- **Promoting understanding and respect** by creating an environment in which all employees are culturally sensitive – for example, pronouncing names correctly and respecting their colleagues' cultures
- **Providing fair opportunities for progression**, including professional development and training, facilitating connections with senior leaders who are Black or from other racially minoritised groups, and improving understanding of senior roles through 'day-in-the-life-of' examples.
- **Dealing effectively with discrimination or misconduct**, with transparent protocols for action and support for people from marginalised groups who experience discrimination in the workplace.



Black male student
20–25 years old

"The fact that there isn't a ceiling for me to reach would make me stay in the company longer. Cause I can keep pushing myself to climb up the ladder within the company. You know, work better, push my boundaries."



02 –

APPLYING FOR JOBS



2.1

FINDING JOB OPPORTUNITIES

To get an accurate picture of companies and job opportunities, Black Gen Z typically use multiple social media platforms when searching for jobs. Companies' presence on social media is extremely important to Black Gen Z – they feel more able to trust employers who make active efforts to connect with them, and view social media as an important way to understand a company's culture, ethos and vision.

LinkedIn is the most common social media platform used by Black Gen Z to find work (47 per cent), followed by Instagram (37 per cent) and Glassdoor (27 per cent).

47%

of Black Gen Z use
LinkedIn to find work

37%

of Black Gen Z use
Instagram to find work

27%

of Black Gen Z use
Glassdoor to find work

Figure 5: Which social media platforms do you use to find work?

Black Gen Z see LinkedIn as the **traditional route** to access information about companies and a wide range of job opportunities, while LinkedIn profiles allow Black Gen Z to showcase their skills easily during the application process.

However, Black Gen Z also noted that salary information is not always available via LinkedIn, and that it is more appropriate for full-time professional roles (rather than part-time roles, which may be more relevant while they are in education). By comparison, **Instagram and Glassdoor felt more reliable to Black Gen Z in terms of providing a transparent picture of companies** which is not always available via other platforms. For example, **Instagram comments** and **Glassdoor reviews** give Black Gen Z insights into candidates' experiences of the interview process, and employees' views on the workplace. Black Gen Z also appreciate information on Glassdoor such as working **hours, pay and accessibility**.



Black female student
16–19 years old

"If I was actively looking for work, [I would use] LinkedIn [...] it feels more professional. You can just search for, let's say, a company name or something, and it'll come up with names associated with the company and different job opportunities."

Over half of Black Gen Z may be open to applying for jobs shared by a social media influencer (52 per cent), with around a third saying that they definitely would (32 per cent). Based on their use of platforms like LinkedIn and Instagram to find job opportunities, advertising jobs via social media influencers may be a potential area of growth for employers looking to target job opportunities to Black Gen Z via social media platforms.

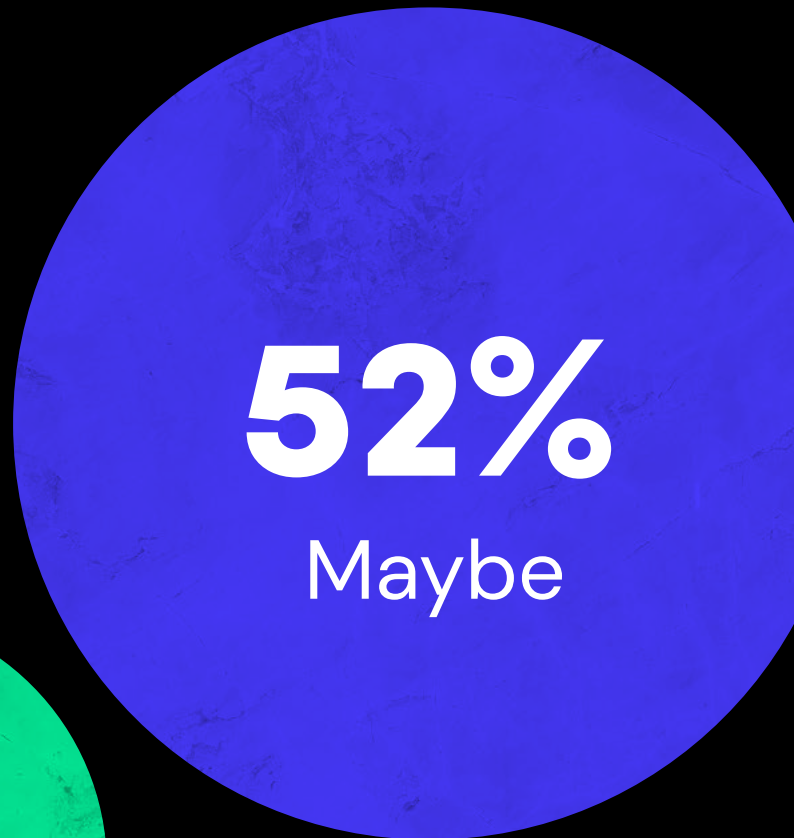
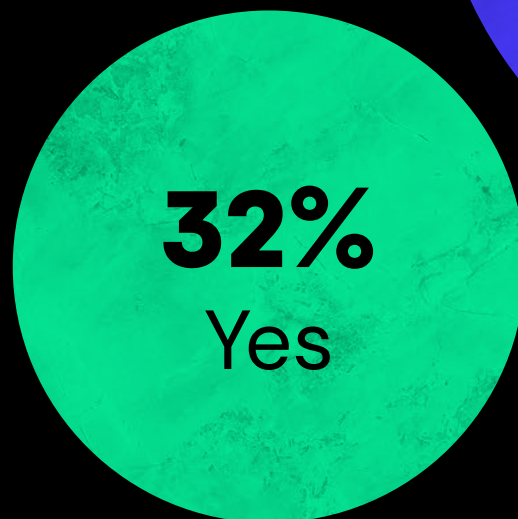


Figure 6: Would you apply for a job if it was shared by a social media influencer?



Black female student
20–25 years old

"I'd probably start with Glassdoor because out of all like the job seeking websites, I find they're the most clear and very upfront about key areas. What matters the most to me like working hours, pay, where like the actual work is, the location, if I can access it easily. So, I would go there first and then, if that's not giving me what I need, then I'll go to LinkedIn and look around a bit more"

2.2

BARRIERS DURING THE APPLICATION PROCESS

Black Gen Z face a number of barriers while applying for jobs. In our survey, the most commonly reported barrier is **not receiving feedback on interviews**. This is particularly demoralising for those who go through multiple application stages for numerous job opportunities, only to find out that they have been unsuccessful and with no information as to why or how they could improve. Black Gen Z were much more likely to identify not receiving feedback as a barrier (42 per cent) compared to their White Gen Z counterparts (32 per cent – Figure B7).

Black Gen Z also highlighted barriers earlier in the application process. For example, our interviewees described not getting through to the interview stage (and without feedback, not knowing why). Another challenge is **not knowing how to tailor their CV** for different types of roles – 34 per cent of Black Gen Z highlighted this as a barrier during the application process, compared to 24 per cent of White Gen Z.

Figure 7: Barriers faced during the job application process

42%

of Black Gen Z didn't receive feedback on interviews

32%

of White Gen Z didn't receive feedback on interviews

34%

of Black Gen Z didn't know how to tailor their CV to certain roles

24%

of White Gen Z didn't know how to tailor their CV to certain roles



Black female student
16–19 years old

“They tend to overlook all the other good things in your CV if you don’t have that one specific thing. So I feel like if they had just asked me [if] you could explain yourself and show them that you are worthy, even though you don’t have that grade or you don’t have that subject.”

There are also multiple factors which actively discourage Black Gen Z from applying for roles. Over half of Black Gen Z said that they would be put off by **bad reviews from current or former employees** (54 per cent), which is comparable to their Gen Z peers from other ethnic groups. Another key barrier for over half of Black Gen Z (51 per cent) is a **lack of visible diversity or representation** at a company. This matters much more to Black Gen Z than Asian Gen Z (35 per cent) or White Gen Z (24 per cent).

As mentioned in Chapter 1, diversity and inclusion are important priorities for Black Gen Z. Past experiences of racism and discrimination in the workplace are key reasons that Black Gen Z avoid companies that are not racially diverse.

Black Gen Z are also discouraged if they don't feel they meet all the **requirements on the job post** (38 per cent). Not having specific types and/or years of experience, as well as grade requirements, are a key barrier for Black Gen Z. In particular, the Catch-22 of requiring professional experience to gain employment (but not being able to gain professional experience without employment) is frustrating and demotivating for Black Gen Z.

54%

of Black Gen Z would be put off by bad reviews of a company

38%

of Black Gen Z would be put off by not meeting all the job requirements

A lack of visible diversity and representation is a barrier to applying to a job for...

51%

of Black Gen Z

35%

of Asian Gen Z

24%

of White Gen Z

Figure 8: What is most likely to put you off when applying for a specific job?



Black student
16–19 years old

“I’m more limited [...] because I don’t have that much experience in the field that I’m looking for a job in, but at the same time if they don’t give me an opportunity, I won’t be able to have that experience [...] [I feel] drained, like exhausted.”

26 per cent of Black Gen Z indicate that written or maths-based tests are a barrier to applying for specific jobs, while **52 per cent of Black Gen Z say that these tests would not put them off from applying**. Interestingly, this contradicts employers’ findings that these tests are a common dropout point for Black Gen Z, and/or a stage at which Black Gen Z under-perform⁸. This difference in Black Gen Z and employer perspectives may reflect the limited feedback received by Black Gen Z on their applications. As most of our interviewees had not completed these kinds of tests in their applications to date, this may be an area that requires further research.

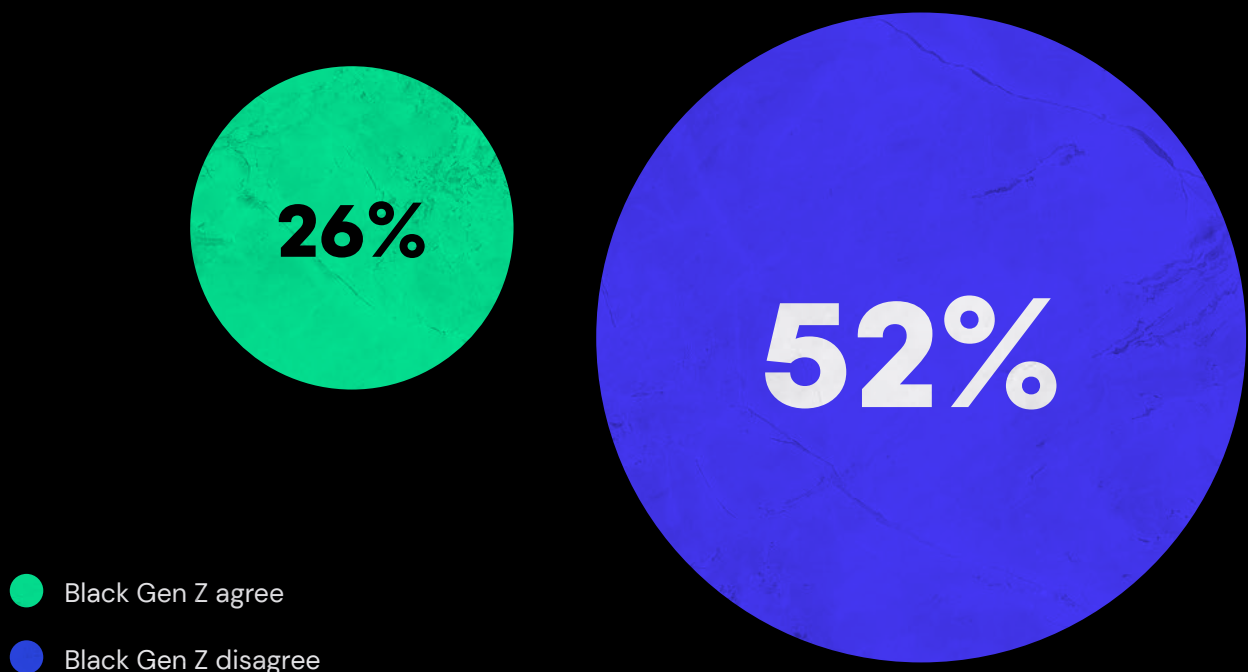


Figure 9: I would avoid applying for a job if it included a written or maths-based test

⁸Internal employer findings shared confidentially with the Black Talent Research project.

2.3

NAVIGATING THE APPLICATION PROCESS

In addition to the barriers described above, Black Gen Z describe navigating further challenges during the application process linked to racial discrimination.

22%

of Black Gen Z changed their name on a job application

12%

of Asian Gen Z changed their name on a job application

7%

of White Gen Z changed their name on a job application

Figure 10: Have you ever changed your name in a job application to have a better chance of becoming successful?

Twenty-two per cent of Black Gen Z reported **changing their name on a job application to improve their chances of success**. While these respondents were in the minority, Black Gen Z were much more likely to report doing this compared to their Asian Gen Z and White Gen Z peers (12 per cent and 7 per cent respectively – Figure B10). Where Black Gen Z have done this, they have typically used more 'White'-sounding middle names and/or omitted an African or Muslim middle or surnames. This is often due to previous experiences of microaggressions or discrimination when including their full names on job applications, and/or because they feel more likely to be rejected if they include their full names.

Among the 78 per cent of Black Gen Z who **do not choose to change their names on job applications**, there is still a strong awareness of potential discrimination or bias during the application process. However, these participants describe not changing their names for the following reasons: they are proud of their heritage; they know employers will eventually 'find out' about their ethnicity at later stages of the application process; and/or they would not want to work for an employer who would only hire them based on a 'white-washed' application.



Black non-binary employee
20-25 years old

I always shorten my [African] last name as well [...] It makes the interview feel less awkward when they say my name [...] It feels like, um, it feels like it's a bit harder to then engage with them after your first introduction is you correcting them? So I shorten my name [...] It's a more Western name and I've done it all my life, like in school, to just make life easier [...] It takes the focus off my name, and more on me I guess. So they don't judge me, [by thinking] 'oh her name's really hard to say', but more like, 'oh she's a good candidate' or 'she's not the good candidate'."



Black female student
20–25 years old

“Realistically, even if you get the job and you show up, you are still gonna be Black [...] or you’re still gonna have that name. And realistically you want to be employed by someone who sees you and wants you as a person, not who you are trying to be on the CV”



Black male student
20–25 years old

“When it comes to the screening process, they need to make it more inclusive. Maybe we can send in our CVs but not send in our names. Judge your work ethic rather than based off your name.”

There is also a notable difference in how confident Black Gen Z feel about their self-presentation at interview compared to their peers. Only **35 per cent of Black Gen Z said they would feel confident wearing their natural hair to a job interview**, compared to 76 per cent of White Gen Z and 67 per cent of Asian Gen Z (Figure B11).

- White Gen Z who would feel confident to wear their natural hair to an interview
- Asian Gen Z who would feel confident to wear their natural hair to an interview
- Black Gen Z who would feel confident to wear their natural hair to an interview

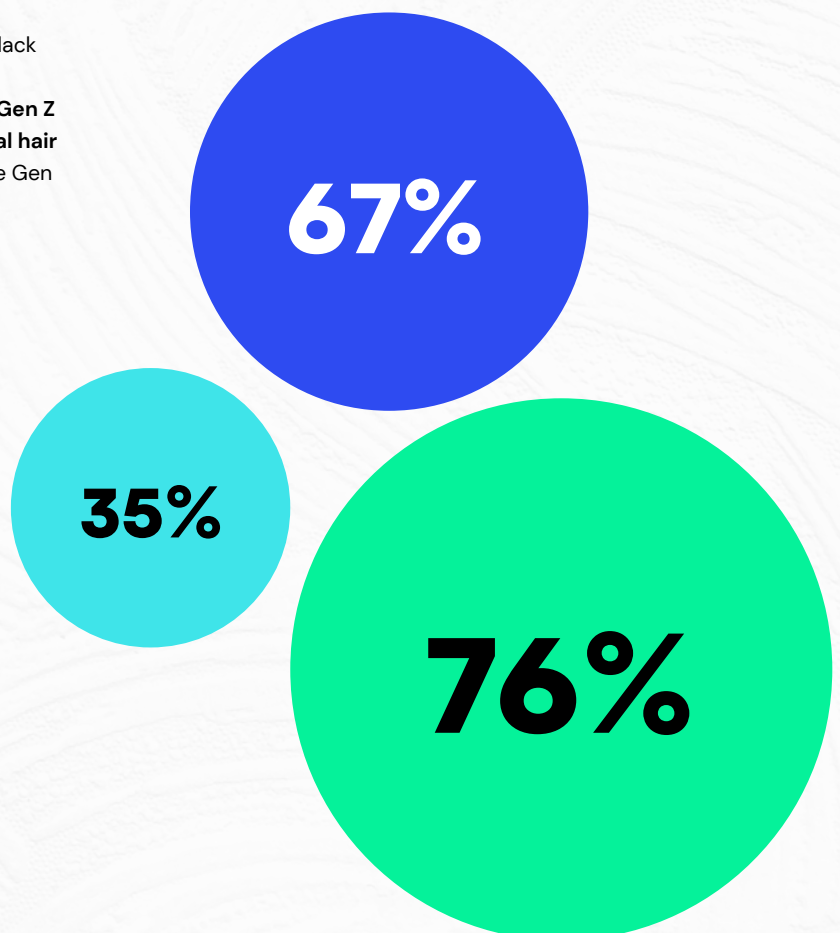


Figure 11: How confident would you be to wear your natural hair to a job interview?

Looking at the results by gender identity, **52 per cent of female Black Gen Z and 37 per cent of non-binary Black Gen Z do not feel confident wearing their natural hair to an interview.** This contrasts with 61 per cent of male Black Gen Z who do feel confident doing this, highlighting the intersectional barriers navigated by female and non-binary Black Gen Z when applying for jobs. Black Gen Z women and non-binary people feel concerned about not being seen as professional if they wore their natural hair to interview. They also feel that employers should be more aware of how difficult it can be for Black people to have to adapt themselves to be 'workplace appropriate'.

61%

of male Black Gen Z **do** feel confident wearing their natural hair to an interview

37%

52%

- Female Black Gen Z **who do not** feel confident wearing their natural hair to an interview
- Non-binary Black Gen Z **who do not** feel confident wearing their natural hair to an interview

Figure 12: How confident would you be to wear your natural hair to a job interview?⁹



Black non-binary employee
20-25 years old

"I feel like it could be seen as unprofessional almost which I know it shouldn't be – but it is. You still get that perception. Like no matter how many times you'll tell people, it's professional. It's still this big debate about a black woman's hair being for the workplace."



Black female student
20-25 years old

"I would very much love to wear my hair to, to work like, cause who wouldn't? [It's] the people that are around you just constantly wanting to like fiddle with it or, um, you know, you are being told that your hair are distractions to other people and like, it's my hair."

⁹Participants who identified as gender fluid or who preferred not to state their gender not included, due to small sample sizes.

2.4

ENABLERS DURING THE APPLICATION PROCESS

In addition to barriers and experiences of discrimination navigated by Black Gen Z during the application process, we also explored factors which make the application process easier and more appealing for Black Gen Z.

Including salaries on job adverts is a key factor that encourages Black Gen Z to apply for a job (63 per cent), and this was similarly important across all Gen Z ethnic groups (Figure B13). Financial requirements – paying living costs, budgeting and achieving a good standard of living – are unsurprisingly a key factor for Black Gen Z when seeking employment. Transparency about pay is therefore vital to help with expectations during the application process, and to inform potential pay negotiations later on in the process.

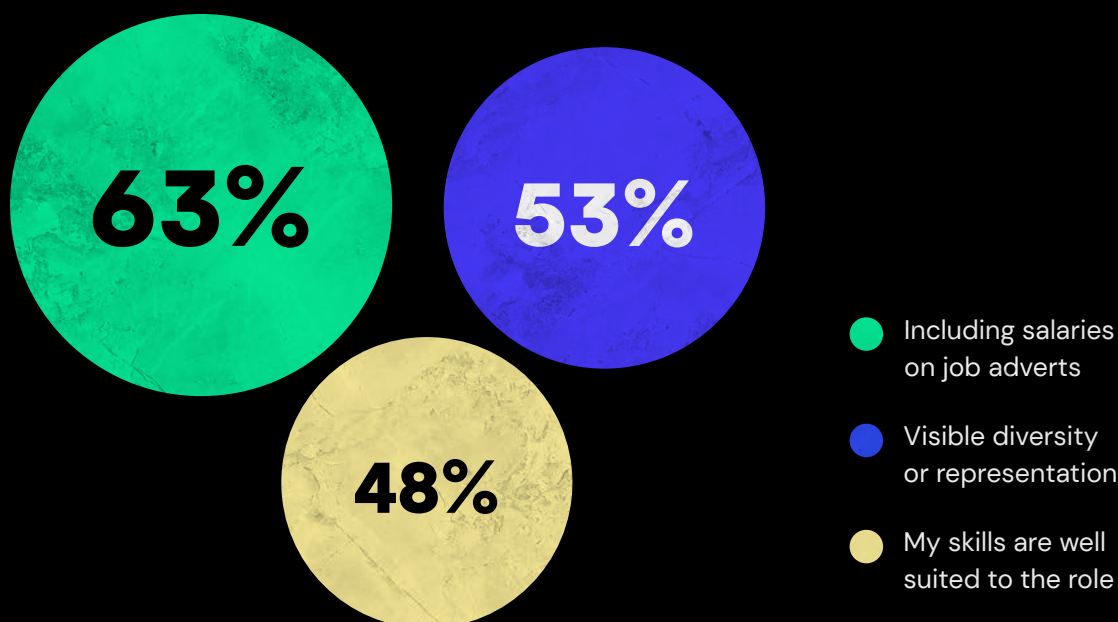


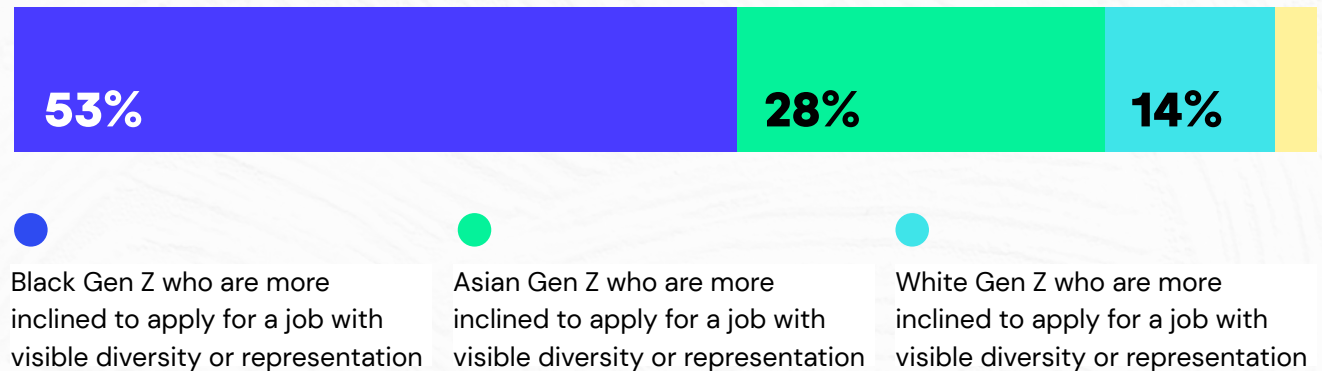
Figure 13: What is most likely to attract you when applying for a specific job?



Black male student
16–19 years old

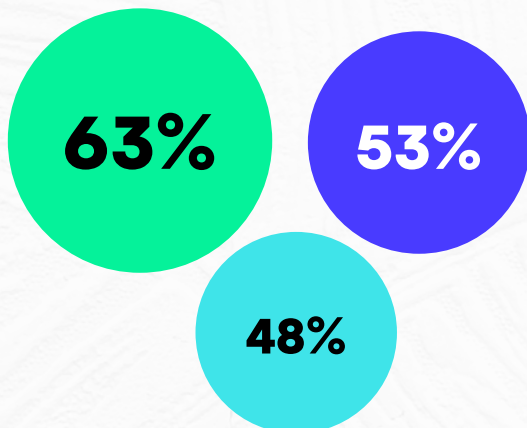
“Many times, I’m doing many different applications, so I’m not gonna apply for similar roles if the pay is much less. Demystifying the salary range is very important to me cause I feel like I’m not wasting my time.”

Consistent with a lack of diversity being a barrier, Black Gen Z highlight **visible diversity or representation** as a factor which encourages them to apply for a job. This is much more important for Black Gen Z (53 per cent) than Asian Gen Z (28 per cent) or White Gen Z (14 per cent). In particular, seeing Black representation at senior levels is encouraging and inspiring for Black Gen Z, as a sign that they should be able to progress at the organisation as well.



Black female employee
20–25 years old

“Knowing that there’s Black women or just women in general, in senior management is very important, knowing that I can make progress within that field or that company myself, it’s very good to learn.”



Another key factor for Black Gen Z is feeling that their **skills are well-suited to the role** (48 per cent). This is linked to being able to excel during the application process, and being able to thrive in a job where they are capable and appreciated.

- Including salaries on job adverts
- My skills are well suited to the role
- Visible diversity or representation

Figure 13: What is most likely to attract you when applying for a specific job?



Black female student
16–19 years old

“Where I feel like my skills are appreciated, I feel it’s important [...] if that’s something you wanna put your life into, then it should be something you are happy in, something you actually enjoy.”

03 – IN THE WORKPLACE



3.1

BARRIERS IN THE WORKPLACE

In our interviews, Black Gen Z describe a range of barriers in the workplace which caused them to leave their jobs. **Poor working conditions** are a key issue, including:

- Being poorly paid
- Being given unrealistic workloads and/or deadlines
- A lack of flexible working options
- A lack of compassion and empathy from managers
- Insufficient progression opportunities



Black female student

20–25 years old

“Feeling underpaid, underappreciated, overworked, with no compassion for me as a human being [...] that would [all] make me wanna leave.”



Black female student

16–19 years old

“One big one [is] lack of progression [...] Some of my colleagues, just not feeling like they were truly like valued within the company [...] they’d been there for a certain amount of time, and they felt like they deserved feel a different position [...] and they just hadn’t been thought of. And yeah, they were better off going elsewhere to another company where they felt better valued and better treated.”



Black Gen Z also highlight **experiences of discrimination** related to race, gender, class, disability and religion as a key barrier to remaining in a job. Our interviewees describe experiences including:

- Being underappreciated or undervalued compared to White colleagues
- Microaggressions and hostility from non-Black colleagues
- Feeling isolated and not being able to be their authentic selves in the workplace



Black male employee

20–25 years old

“My work [was] maybe deemed a lower level than my white colleague who [was] the same level as me, but cause of the fact that I’m not white, I seemed inferior to him – which is not the case [...] The instance where that happened, it made me feel really uncomfortable in the sense that – am I really valued or am I really appreciated? Am I just here to promote or boost the numbers of how many people that are not white? It kind of made me feel like a bit worthless in a way.”

Importantly, Black Gen Z emphasise that the key issue is not just experiencing discrimination, but **employers failing to deal with racism and other forms of discrimination in the workplace**. Black Gen Z described disappointment and frustration at employers who:

- Do not listen to or support Black employees who report experiences of discrimination
- Choose to ‘sweep discrimination under the rug’ rather than deal with issues head on



**Black male student
& employee**

20–25 years old

“Not [just] racism occurring, but how the organization deals with it [...] I have a very zero tolerance on, I guess any type of like brushing under the rug or anything like that.”

3.2

NAVIGATING THE WORKPLACE

Only **31 per cent** of Black Gen Z feel they can be their authentic selves at work, and **nearly half** feel they cannot be their authentic selves at work (45 per cent). By comparison, two-thirds of White Gen Z (66 per cent) and half of Asian Gen Z (55 per cent) feel that they can be their authentic selves at work (Figure B14).

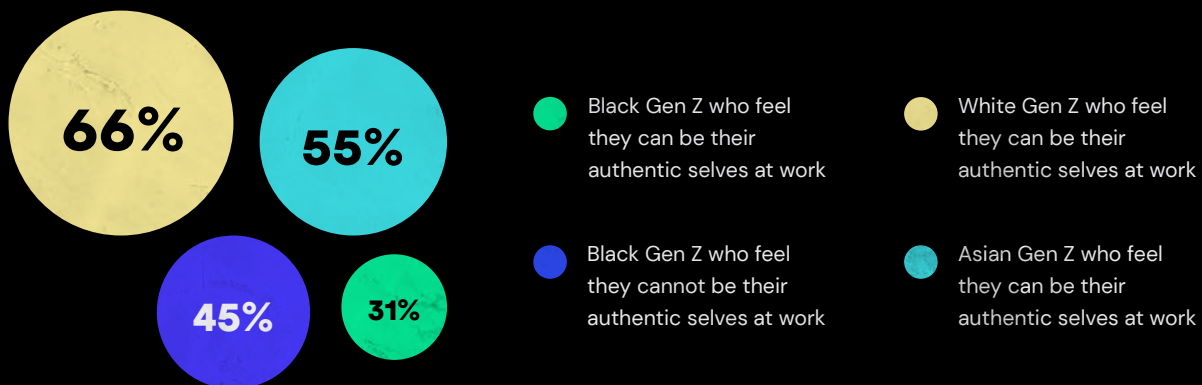


Figure 14: I feel like I can be my authentic self at work

What does this mean for Black Gen Z in the workplace? Where they are not able to be their authentic selves at work, our participants describe:

- 01** Needing to **code-switch**, changing the way they speak and their language to 'fit in' with their colleagues
- 02** Changing their **self-presentation**, such as avoiding wearing their natural hair (particularly for Black Gen Z women, as discussed earlier) or feeling uncomfortable wearing religious clothing such as hijabs
- 03** Avoiding behaviours which mark them out as **'different'** due to their cultures – for example, not bringing home-cooked food to the office for lunch, and not sharing different life experiences or opinions in the workplace.



Black male student
16–19 years old

"If you're unhappy or extremely uncomfortable in the workplace, then you're gonna be far less productive. Cause you're generally just under different mental pressures. So your general concentration and focus on motivation is gonna be far less [than your peers]"

These experiences have significant, negative impacts on Black Gen Z. Where they are unable to be their authentic selves in the workplace, our participants describe experiencing **stress and anxiety**, feeling **demotivated and under-performing** at work. Black Gen Z also note that the energy they have to expend on masking and code-switching can have a **negative impact on their productivity**, compared to their White peers who do not have to worry about these factors.

Importantly, Black Gen Z are **less able to be their authentic selves in less diverse workplaces**. When working in teams or companies where they are the single or one of very few Black employees, Black Gen Z feel less understood by their employers and colleagues, and are more likely to feel excluded from day-to-day work culture.

In workplaces where they are able to be their authentic selves, Black Gen Z describe clear benefits. Where they feel safe, supported and appreciated in the workplace, Black Gen Z are more likely to **thrive** in the workplace, **perform** to the best of their ability, feel **passionate** and **committed**, and to **stay** with their employer for longer.

In a further indicator of their inability to be their authentic selves in the workplace, almost **half of Black Gen Z have changed their name to make it easier for colleagues, classmates or teachers to pronounce** (47 per cent). This compares to just 14 per cent of White Gen Z and 24 per cent of Asian Gen Z (Figure B15).

47% of Black Gen Z have changed their names to make it easier for others to pronounce

14% of White Gen Z have changed their names to make it easier for others to pronounce

24% of Asian Gen Z have changed their names to make it easier for others to pronounce

Figure 15: Have you ever changed or altered your name to make it easier for colleagues, classmates or teachers to pronounce?



Black female student
20–25 years old

“[Being your authentic self] has a massive impact [...] when you are happy and when you actually find joy and reward in your work, [...] you’d interact better with your co-workers. I feel like you’d be more likely to get promotions because people can see that there’s like a light inside of you.”

Just over a third of Black Gen Z feel they **have to socialise or drink with colleagues out of work to fit in with the company culture** (37 per cent). Results are fairly similar across Gen Z ethnic groups (Figure B16). It is important to note that work-related social events that involve drinking alcohol can exclude or alienate Black Gen Z and other employees who do not drink for religious, cultural or other reasons. Black Gen Z recommended that employers should encourage other ways of socialising at work to be more inclusive of employees from a range of cultural backgrounds.

- Strongly agree or agree
- Neither agree nor disagree
- Strongly disagree or disagree

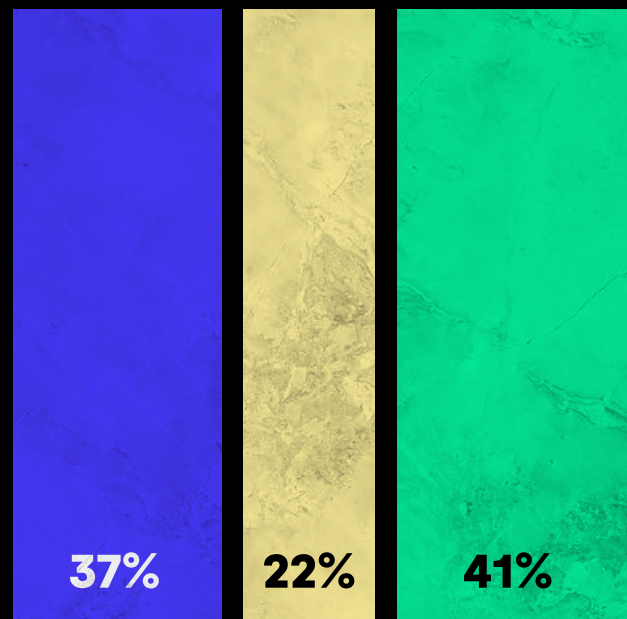


Figure 16: I feel like I have to socialise or drink with colleagues outside of work in order to fit in with the company culture



3.3

SUPPORT & PROGRESSION IN THE WORKPLACE

Among those who are working, Black Gen Z are less likely to be aware of career progression opportunities, and are less optimistic about their chances of promotion compared to their peers.

Around **half of Black Gen Z are aware of the career progression opportunities available to them** (46 per cent). This is much lower than their Asian Gen Z and White Gen Z peers (63 per cent and 69 per cent respectively – Figure B17).

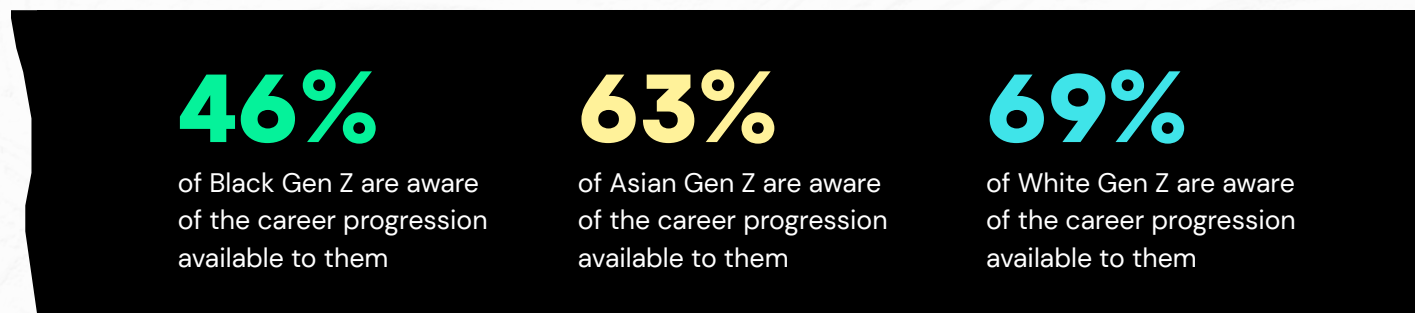


Figure 17: I am aware of the avenues of career progression that are available to me in my role

Additionally, **less than a third of Black Gen Z are satisfied with their chances of securing a promotion** (29 per cent). By comparison, over half of White Gen Z (52 per cent) and nearly two-thirds of Asian Gen Z (62 per cent) are satisfied with their chances of securing a promotion (Figure B18).

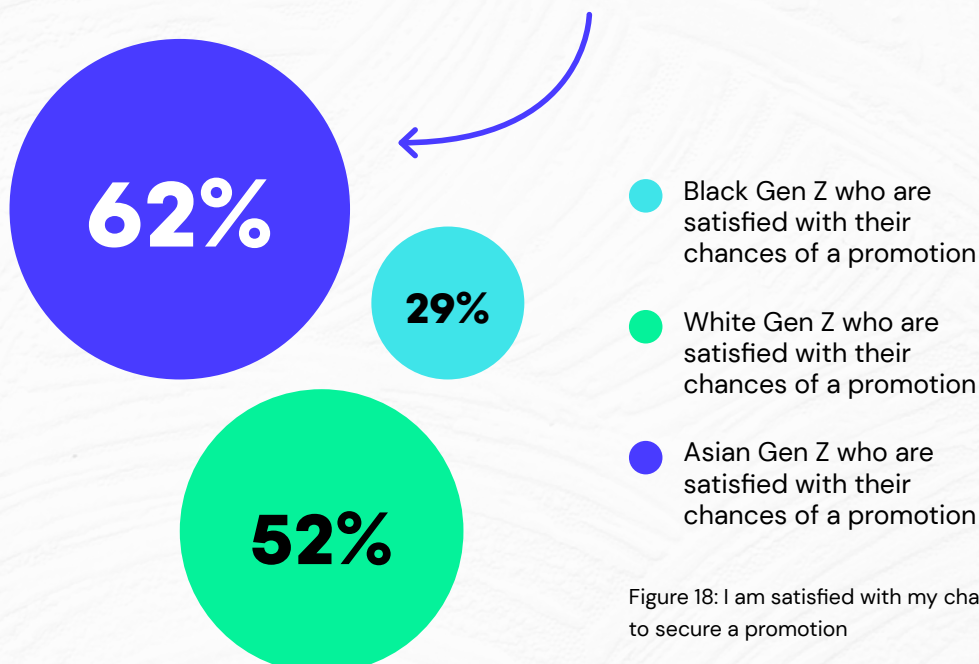


Figure 18: I am satisfied with my chance to secure a promotion

Black Gen Z's uncertainty around their chances of promotion may relate to the **limited support they receive in the workplace**. Only **36 per cent of Black Gen Z participants feel they are supported in pursuing their professional interests**, compared to 48 per cent of Asian Gen Z and 58 per cent of White Gen Z (58 per cent) (Figure B19).



36%

of Black Gen Z feel they are supported in pursuing their professional interests

48%

of Asian Gen Z feel they are supported in pursuing their professional interests

58%

of White Gen Z feel they are supported in pursuing their professional interests

Figure 19: My employer supports me in pursuing my professional interests



Black female student
16–19 years old

"If I built long lasting friendships there [...] if the pay is manageable and I'm being treated well by my co-workers and by my manager, and if I enjoy working at the company, then that would make me stay."



When describing a supportive environment at work, Black Gen Z emphasise the following factors would make them want to stay with an employer for the long term:

- A friendly working environment, including being treated well by co-workers and managers
- A diverse and inclusive workplace
- An employer who makes them feel valued as an individual
- Work which pays well and rewards employees fairly
- Opportunities to develop, including new skills and knowledge as well as fair access to promotion

Black Gen Z value discussing personal issues with a work-based mentor (41 per cent). For Black Gen Z, mentors play an important role in supporting their mental health and wellbeing, as well as a source of professional development advice. Black mentors are particularly valued as a source of support and guidance from those who understand and share experiences of being racially minoritised.

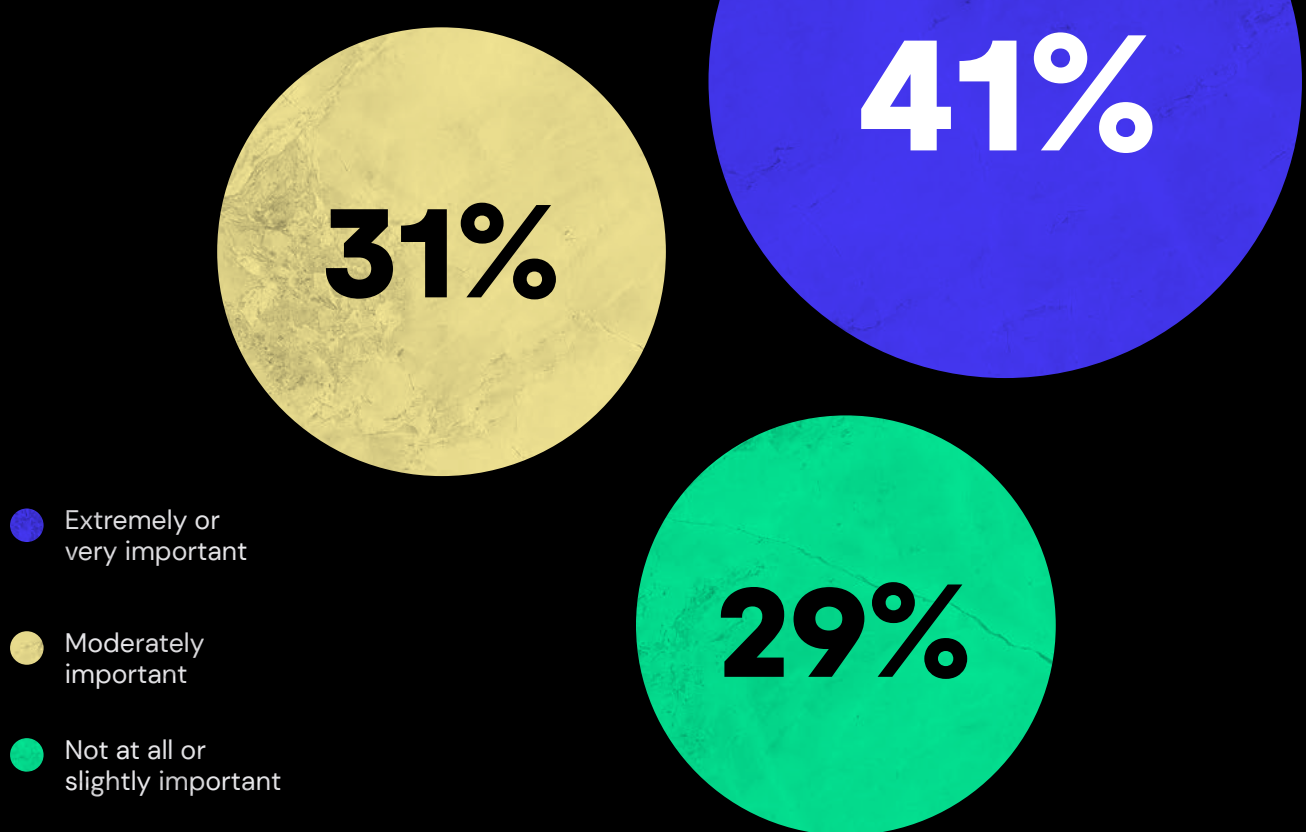


Figure 20: How important is it for you to be able to discuss personal issues with a work-based mentor?



Black female student
16–19 years old

“I feel like, yes, make these [D&I training] opportunities available and have them there, but don’t like, don’t make me feel othered.”

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR EMPLOYERS

Based on our key findings, what should employers do to reach, recruit and retain Black Gen Z talent?



DIVERSITY

Ensure your recruitment process is transparent, creative and supportive

Develop transparent, creative job ads. Clearly state the salary, and explain what the application process involves at each stage. This helps Black Gen Z to trust employers, to evaluate whether the position meets their financial requirements, and to determine whether they have the required time and capacity for the application process. Use your social media platforms to advertise jobs, including opportunities that are specifically targeted at Black Gen Z candidates.

Minimise bias when assessing candidates. Name-blind job applications to minimise potential bias in the recruitment process – and tell your candidates that you do this, as potential discrimination related to non-White names can be a source of anxiety for Black Gen Z. Provide training for all those involved in recruitment, to minimise bias and microaggressions in the hiring process.

Provide feedback to all candidates. Black Gen Z currently receive insufficient feedback on their job applications – this means that they don't always know how to improve in future. Providing opportunities for feedback at each stage of the application process is therefore a vital form of support for your candidates.

EQUITY

Offer fair opportunities for Black Gen Z to develop and progress

Offer well-paid jobs with clear routes to progression. Black Gen Z value jobs that offer financial security and opportunities for personal development across a wide range of sectors, including those in which Black people have been historically underrepresented. Ensure your roles are fairly remunerated (with the Real Living Wage as a baseline), with transparent criteria and processes for promotion.

Provide targeted professional development and training opportunities. Ensure that Black Gen Z talent has space to grow and develop at your company, including through targeted professional development and training opportunities. Actively involve Black Gen Z employees in activities that will lead to progression in their careers. At present, Black Gen Z do not feel they are sufficiently supported to progress at work, nor do they see themselves reflected in senior positions.

INCLUSION

Create a workplace where Black Gen Z are safe, supported and valued

Create an inclusive culture. Encourage all your employees to respect diverse cultures. This includes improving awareness of the experiences and potential challenges faced by marginalised groups, and celebrating employees from a range of backgrounds. Black Gen Z are more likely to feel comfortable being their authentic selves – and therefore realise their full potential – in such workplaces.

Acknowledge, value and reward Black employees' contributions fairly. In workplaces where Black Gen Z describe being able to thrive, their work and strengths are acknowledged, valued and rewarded fairly. Embed these practices at all levels in your organisation to ensure Black Gen Z employees are valued as much as their peers.

Provide mentoring and pastoral support. Set up mentoring and buddying schemes for Black Gen Z employees. This provides targeted pastoral support so that Black Gen Z are supported professionally and personally by someone who is more likely to share their lived experiences.

Deal with discrimination transparently and effectively. Ensure there are transparent, consistent processes to report and address discrimination – whether experienced with colleagues or customers. Where it occurs, provide support for employees who have experienced discrimination, and ensure that the issues are understood and dealt with in a timely way.



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